A 15–second storyboard

Portrait 9:16, readable with the sound off: the horde first, then the two things the player does (pick, build), the payoff, two escalations and a challenge the viewer wants to answer.

0–2 s · Hook

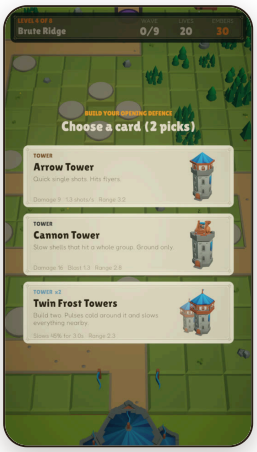


A column of skeletons winds across the island toward the gate.

THEY'RE COMING FOR THE GATE

Sound: Drums, bones rattling

2–4 s · The draft

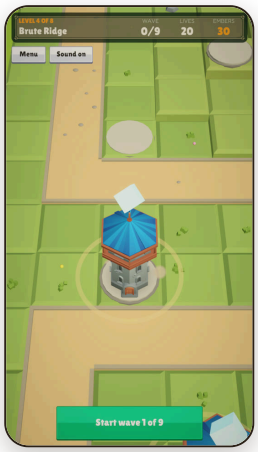


Three cards; a finger picks one.

PICK YOUR TOWERS

Sound: Card flip

4–6 s · Build

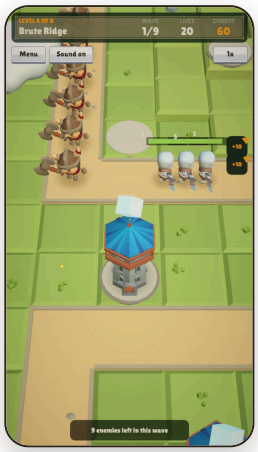


A tower lands on a glowing pad beside the road.

TAP TO BUILD

Sound: Stone thud

6–8 s · Payoff



Shots land; Brutes fall apart into bone bits; embers fly.

WATCH THEM CRUMBLE

Sound: Kill streak rising

8–10 s · Twist

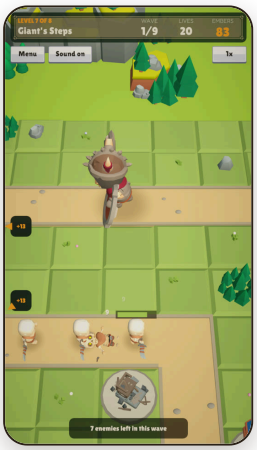


Wraiths float over the marsh the walkers wade through.

SOME OF THEM FLY

Sound: Whoosh

10–12 s · Threat



A Bone Giant steps into view.

SOME ARE HUGE

Sound: Heavy footsteps, music ducks

12–13.5 s · Challenge

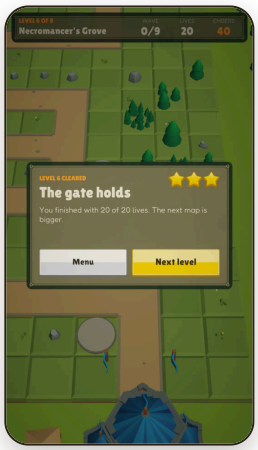


Level 7's last wave: 4 Bone Giants and their escort on the road at once.

4 GIANTS. ONE GATE. CAN YOU HOLD IT?

Sound: Music stops

13.5–15 s · End card



Victory and three stars; the edit lays the title and a Play button over it.

BONEMARCH · PLAY FREE

Sound: Win jingle

Every frame comes from the game. A PlayMode test (`AdTests.AdFrames_CaptureTheBeats`) plays levels 8, 4, 5, 7 and 6 with the cards on offer and the pads near the road, and saves a phone-sized frame at each beat. Only the challenge is staged: it sends level 7's real last wave onto the road at once.

2 · THE CPI TEST

Three hooks, one decision

A hybrid-casual game has to pass two gates: people must install it cheaply enough, and come back for its depth. The test reads both.

Creative variants

VARIANT	FIRST 2 SECONDS	WHAT IT TESTS
A · The horde (above)	A column of skeletons heads for the gate	The genre's promise: a wave and a defence; the widest audience
B · The draft	Three cards and a question: "Which would you take?"	Is the draft, the game's difference, the hook?
C · The giant	A Bone Giant walks past a weak defence toward the gate	Viewers who want to fix a losing board

Test design

	SETTING (PLANNING ASSUMPTIONS)
Channels	Meta (Facebook/Instagram) first; an ad network after a pass
Platform and build	Android, the APK behind a store listing with analytics on (the KPI plan overleaf)
Rounds	Up to three creative rounds before the kill decision; change the hook first, as it is the cheapest
Reading	Compare variants only once each has enough impressions and installs for its numbers to settle

Go / iterate / kill

Go

- CPI at or under the casual average on Android, $0.65 [2]
- D1 at least 45% [1]
- D7 at least 15% [1]
- D30 at least 10% (soft launch) [1]

Soft launch with the KPI plan overleaf.

Iterate

- CPI good, D1 short: the first level loses them (the draft, the first build)
- D1 good, D7 short: the depth isn't landing; check where the funnel stops (levels 3 to 5)
- CPI over the line: try the next hook

Kill

- After three creative rounds, no hook near the CPI line
- Or D7 stays near the market's top quarter for all games (7 to 8% [3]) after the fixes, far below the 15% a hybrid-casual game needs

The theme or the depth is not landing: test a new theme for the same rules before more levels.

Where the lines come from. The retention lines are a publisher's stated bar for hybrid-casual [1]; the CPI line is the casual-game average on Android over a year [2] (iOS averaged $4.83 in the same report). For scale: across all mobile games at the end of 2024, the top quarter's D1 was 26 to 28% [3]. Each publisher sets its own lines; these are a starting point, to be replaced by the publisher's benchmarks.

[1] Thibault de Vésinne-Larüe, Voodoo's head of publishing, reported by WN Hub, 25 July 2023: "hybrid-casual retention thresholds", wnhub.io/news/analytics/item-41307

[2] Liftoff and GameRefinery, Casual Games 2024 (data April 2023 to April 2024), via Game Dev Reports, 3 May 2024: "Liftoff & GameRefinery: Casual Games in 2024", gamedevreports.substack.com/p/liftoff-and-gamerefinery-casual-games

[3] GameAnalytics, 2025 Mobile Gaming Benchmarks (end of 2024), via Game Dev Reports, 17 February 2025: "GameAnalytics: Mobile gaming benchmarks in 2025", gamedevreports.substack.com/p/gameanalytics-mobile-gaming-benchmarks

3 · KPI PLAN

What to measure, and what to change

The prototype has no analytics yet. These are the events to add, each tied to a question the design needs answered.

EVENT (TO ADD)	FIELDS	ANSWERS
`level_start`	level, attempt	Where players stop (the level funnel)
`level_end`	level, result, wave, lives, stars, minutes, share_at_2x	Is the curve right? Is the game calm or slow?
`draft_pick`	level, wave, offered, picked	Do players take boons? Do they find each level's counter?
`tower_built`	level, wave, tower, pad (plain · hill · ruin)	Do players use the landmarks?
`wave_end`	level, wave, leaks_by_enemy, embers_left	Which enemy beats them, and are embers short?
`crystal`	level, taken, seen	Do players look around the map?
`session_start`	day_since_install, level	Retention (D1, D7, D30)

KPIs and targets

KPI	TARGET OR BENCHMARK	IF IT MISSES
D1 retention	≥ 45% [1]	Level 1 and 2: the first draft, the first build, the first upgrade
D7 retention	≥ 15% [1]	The level funnel: where the walls are; the boons' worth
Win rate per level	Compare with the first-time bot (workbook)	Where people and bots disagree, people are right: refit the level's health
Boon pick rate	Set from the first cohort	Bots find boons near-neutral; if players skip them too, redesign them (BALANCE.md)
Leaks by the level's new enemy	Set from the first cohort	Players don't find the counter: make the intro and the card louder
Share of play at 2×	Set from the first cohort	High everywhere: the calm reads as slow; shorten the waves

Watch these waves first

Where the first-time bot (workbook) loses most often: **level 8 wave 8 (25%), level 7 wave 9 (22%), level 5 wave 3 (15%), level 6 wave 5 (12%), level 6 wave 8 (12%)**. Bots aren't people, but these are the first places to look in the level_end and wave_end data.

Nothing guessed

Targets with a source carry its number; the rest are set from the first real cohort instead of guessed. The bots' results in the workbook are the baseline the real data is read against.

[1] Thibault de Vésinne-Larüe, Voodoo's head of publishing, reported by WN Hub, 25 July 2023: "hybrid-casual retention thresholds", wnhub.io/news/analytics/item-41307
[2] Liftoff and GameRefinery, Casual Games 2024 (data April 2023 to April 2024), via Game Dev Reports, 3 May 2024: "Liftoff & GameRefinery: Casual Games in 2024", gamedevreports.substack.com/p/liftoff-and-gamerefinery-casual-games
[3] GameAnalytics, 2025 Mobile Gaming Benchmarks (end of 2024), via Game Dev Reports, 17 February 2025: "GameAnalytics: Mobile gaming benchmarks in 2025", gamedevreports.substack.com/p/gameanalytics-mobile-gaming-benchmarks